

GLOSSARY

Direct object The noun or pronoun that is receiving the action of the verb.

Intransitive verb A verb that does not require an object.

Transitive verb A verb that must be used with an object.

Word order

Like regular verbs, phrasal verbs can be transitive or intransitive. Transitive phrasal verbs require a direct object to receive the action, while intransitive phrasal verbs, such as *get up* or *eat out*, make sense without an object. The verb and adverb in a transitive adverb phrasal verb can usually be separated by the direct object.

Daniel was **taking**
me out for lunch.

direct object

This adverb phrasal verb is transitive, so it can be separated by the direct object.



Identifying when a phrasal verb can be separated

Some transitive phrasal verbs can be separated by a direct object; others cannot be separated. A simple way to test whether a phrasal verb is separable or inseparable is to place the pronoun *it* (representing the direct object) between the verb and the adverb or preposition. If the resulting phrase makes sense, that phrasal verb can be separated.

transitive adverb
phrasal verb

pick up

pick **it** up



This phrase makes sense, so the phrasal verb is separable.

transitive prepositional
phrasal verb

look after

look **it** after



This phrase does not make sense, so the phrasal verb is inseparable.

was **taking** **me out** for lunch.
looking forward to the game.

look forward to
look over
look out
look through
look at
look after

Adverb-prepositional phrasal verbs

Some phrasal verbs are made up of a verb, followed by an adverb and a preposition. Like prepositional phrasal verbs, these must have a direct object, and the parts of the phrasal verb cannot be separated by this object.

Paulo was **looking**
forward to the game.

adverb

preposition

verb

direct object